

My Experience as a Maverick Global Ambassador

By Joel Tchouke

When I first moved to the United States from Cameroon three years ago, I experienced a mixture of excitement and uncertainty. Leaving my home country meant entering a completely new environment where the language, culture, and academic system were unfamiliar. Everyday interactions required adjustment. Even simple activities like participating in class discussions or engaging in casual conversations with classmates felt intimidating at first.

During my first semester, I struggled with the language barrier. Although English is taught in Cameroon, using it in academic and social settings in the United States was very different from what I had experienced before. I often hesitated to speak in class because I worried about my accent or making grammatical mistakes. At one point, I was even placed in Intensive English classes, which reinforced my feeling that I was still learning how to function confidently in this new linguistic environment.

Beyond language, the academic culture was also very different. In Cameroon, education tends to emphasize memorization and structured instruction from professors. Students are expected to listen carefully and absorb information. In contrast, American classrooms encourage discussion, debate, and critical thinking. Students often challenge ideas, ask questions, and express their perspectives openly. At first, this was uncomfortable for me because questioning a professor felt unusual compared to my previous educational experiences.

Over time, however, I began to adapt. As I practiced speaking more frequently and participated in class discussions, I realized that making mistakes was part of learning. Slowly, my confidence improved. This transition helped me understand that communication styles and classroom participation are strongly influenced by cultural expectations.

Because I had experienced this transition myself, I was particularly interested in opportunities to support other international students who were going through similar adjustments. That opportunity came when I became a Maverick Global Ambassador working with the retention team in the International Office at Minnesota State University. In this role, my responsibility was to help international students feel welcomed on campus and to assist them in navigating the cultural and academic transitions involved in studying in the United States.

As a Maverick Global Ambassador, I helped organize and facilitate events designed to bring international students together and encourage cultural exchange. These events created opportunities for students from different parts of the world to interact, share their cultural experiences, and build connections with one another.

One event that particularly stood out to me was a campus painting event that we organized for international students. At first glance, the event seemed simple: students gathered in a room with canvases and paint to create artwork while socializing. However, the experience quickly became something much deeper. As students began painting, I noticed that their artwork often reflected elements of their cultural backgrounds, personal experiences, and perspectives on the world.

For example, some students from East Asian countries painted landscapes that emphasized balance, nature, and calmness. Their paintings often included mountains, rivers, and soft color transitions that conveyed harmony. When I spoke with them about their artwork, they explained how nature and balance are deeply connected to cultural traditions in their countries.

Students from Latin American backgrounds often created vibrant and colorful paintings that reflected celebration, music, and community life. Their artwork used bold colors and dynamic patterns, expressing energy and movement. Some students explained that these artistic choices reflected the importance of festivals, music, and community gatherings in their cultures.

Students from African countries, including myself, often incorporated symbols or imagery connected to family, heritage, or landscapes that reminded us of home. Some paintings included representations of villages, sunsets, or traditional patterns inspired by African fabrics. Seeing these pieces reminded me how deeply culture influences the way individuals interpret and represent the world around them.

Observing these differences helped me realize that art can serve as a powerful reflection of cultural identity. Through a simple activity like painting, students were expressing how their cultures shaped the way they see the world.

Another memorable event we organized was a Valentine's Day gathering for international students. While Valentine's Day is widely celebrated in the United States as a holiday focused on romantic relationships, I discovered that many international students had very different perspectives on the meaning of the day.

Some students from certain cultures associated Valentine's Day not only with romantic love but also with friendship and appreciation for family members. Others came from countries where the holiday was not widely celebrated at all. As we discussed these differences during the event, it became clear that something I had begun to see as a normal part of American culture was interpreted very differently across cultures.

Another important event that I helped organize was the International Festival. This event brought together students from many different countries to share their cultures with the wider university community.

One booth that stood out to me was organized by students from Japan. Their booth displayed traditional items such as calligraphy examples and cultural decorations. They also invited visitors to participate in traditional activities, including writing simple Japanese characters using brush-style calligraphy. When I tried the activity myself, I quickly realized how much precision and patience it required. The students explained that calligraphy is not only a writing system but also a form of artistic expression that reflects discipline and balance within Japanese culture.

Another memorable booth was hosted by students from East Africa who were selling traditional handmade bracelets. The bracelets were beautifully crafted with colorful bead patterns that reflected different styles from their region. As they explained the meaning behind the patterns, I realized that the bracelets represented cultural traditions and identities that had been passed down through generations.

The performances during the festival were also a powerful part of the experience. One performance that left a strong impression on me was a Latin American band performing live music. The rhythms were different from what many students on campus were used to hearing, yet the entire room seemed to appreciate it. I remember looking around and seeing students from many different countries clapping along and enjoying the performance together. Even though the music was unfamiliar to many of us, it created a shared sense of excitement and connection.

Another performance that drew a lot of attention was a K-pop dance group that presented choreography inspired by South Korean pop culture. Their performance was energetic and precise, and many students gathered to watch and cheer them on. What struck me most was how students from completely different cultural backgrounds were fascinated by the performance. It showed how cultural expressions from one part of the world can travel across borders and influence people globally.

Throughout the festival, many students also performed music from their home countries. Some sang traditional songs while others played instruments or performed contemporary music influenced by their culture. As a musician myself, I especially appreciated these performances. Even when I did not understand the language of the lyrics, I could still feel the emotion and meaning behind the music.

Watching these performances made me realize that culture can be expressed in many forms—through art, music, crafts, language, and traditions. Each group represented their culture differently, yet everyone shared the same space with curiosity and respect for one another.

Through my experience as a Maverick Global Ambassador, I began to develop a deeper understanding of how culture shapes the way people communicate, express themselves, and interpret the world.

One important realization was that cultural differences are not always obvious at first. Sometimes they appear in small behaviors, such as how comfortable people feel expressing opinions, participating in conversations, or questioning authority.

For example, when I first arrived in the United States, I initially assumed that students who spoke confidently in class were simply more knowledgeable. Over time, I realized that cultural background plays a significant role in how comfortable someone feels speaking publicly. In some cultures, questioning authority figures may be discouraged, while in others it is encouraged.

Recognizing these differences helped me become more patient and empathetic when interacting with students from various cultural backgrounds. Instead of assuming someone was shy or disengaged, I began to consider the cultural context influencing their behavior.

Working closely with students from many countries also helped me reflect on my own cultural identity. As someone from Cameroon, I carry my own values, communication style, and cultural assumptions. Interacting with students from different cultures helped me realize that my perspective is just one among many.

The painting event illustrated this idea clearly. Watching students express their cultures through art made me realize that culture influences not only traditions but also the way people interpret emotions, landscapes, and symbols.

Similarly, the International Festival showed how cultural identity can be expressed through food, dance, music, clothing, and storytelling. Each culture represented itself differently, demonstrating that culture is complex and cannot be reduced to simple stereotypes.

These experiences helped me understand that intercultural engagement is not only about learning facts about other cultures. It is about listening, observing, and being open to perspectives that may be very different from one's own.

Looking ahead, the lessons I learned through my experience as a Maverick Global Ambassador will continue to influence how I interact with others in both academic and professional environments.

As I pursue a career in engineering, I know I will likely work with colleagues from many different countries and cultural backgrounds. Engineering projects often involve global teams where individuals bring diverse perspectives and problem-solving approaches.

Because of my experience working with international students, I now understand the importance of cultural awareness in communication and collaboration. I have learned that effective teamwork requires not only technical knowledge but also empathy, patience, and the ability to understand different perspectives.

In the future, I hope to continue fostering environments where people from different backgrounds feel comfortable sharing their ideas and experiences. Whether I am working on engineering projects, collaborating with international colleagues, or mentoring younger students, I want to approach intercultural interactions with the same openness and curiosity that I developed as a Maverick Global Ambassador.

Most importantly, this experience taught me that cultural diversity strengthens communities and encourages innovation. When people from different backgrounds share their perspectives, they expand the way we understand the world and help us approach problems from new angles.

Looking back on my time as a Maverick Global Ambassador, I realize that the experience transformed the way I understand culture, identity, and human connection. It showed me that intercultural engagement is not simply about recognizing differences, but about appreciating the unique perspectives that each person brings to a shared community.